

Psychology, Applied Psychology and Psychological Sciences

A note to students: This assessment is not testing how well you can recall textbook definitions or name famous researchers. It is designed to understand how you think about human behaviour, mental processes, and the people around you. Students who are genuinely well suited for Psychology at university level tend to be curious about why people act the way they do, why two people can experience the same situation so differently, and how emotions, memory, and relationships shape everyday life. Read each scenario carefully, think it through, and choose the answer that makes the most psychological sense to you.

Section 1: Foundations of Human Behaviour

Q1. Two students join the same new school on the same day. One is cheerful and quickly makes friends. The other stays quiet and takes several weeks to feel comfortable. Neither has had any particularly difficult past experiences. What does this most directly illustrate about human behaviour?

A) One student is behaving correctly and the other is making a social mistake B) Personality differences mean that individuals respond to similar situations in genuinely different ways C) The quieter student is likely experiencing a mental health problem D) Social behaviour is determined entirely by the environment a person grows up in

Q2. A teenager works hard in school not because her parents push her, but because she genuinely finds learning satisfying and wants to understand the world. Which kind of motivation best describes what is driving her behaviour?

A) External motivation driven by rewards and consequences B) Social motivation influenced by peer comparison C) Internal motivation that comes from personal interest and a sense of meaning D) Competitive motivation triggered by wanting to outperform others

Q3. Two brothers grow up in the same household with the same parents. One becomes very organised, careful, and rule-following. The other is spontaneous, creative, and resistant to structure. What does this most usefully suggest about personality?

A) One brother has been raised more effectively than the other B) Personality emerges from a combination of individual factors and cannot be explained by environment alone C) The spontaneous brother is likely to struggle more in adult life D) Personality is fixed at birth and cannot change under any circumstances

Q4. A student who usually does well in exams performs poorly on a test held the morning after a family argument. Her knowledge has not changed, but her performance has. What does this most directly illustrate?

A) That intelligence levels fluctuate from day to day B) That emotional state can significantly affect how well a person performs on a given task C) That exams are not a reliable way to measure what students know D) That family conflict directly damages memory and learning ability

Q5. In a group discussion, a student who holds a strong opinion begins to speak more quietly and agree with others when she realises her view is unpopular. She does not actually change her private belief. What psychological phenomenon does this behaviour most closely reflect?

A) Genuine persuasion through exposure to new arguments B) Social conformity, where a person adjusts their outward behaviour to fit in with a group C) Low intelligence making it difficult to defend one's position D) Introversion making it difficult to express opinions in public

Section 2: Cognition, Learning and Decision-Making

Q6. A student reads through her notes once carefully and feels confident she knows the material. On the exam, she struggles to recall much of it. A classmate who tested himself repeatedly using questions performed far better despite spending less total time studying. What does this most likely reveal?

A) The second student is naturally more intelligent B) Confidence after reading is a reliable indicator of how well something has been learned C) Actively retrieving information from memory tends to strengthen it more than passive re-reading D) Spending less time studying is generally more effective than spending more time

Q7. A person is choosing between two job offers. One pays slightly more but requires a long commute. The other pays a little less but is close to home. Rather than calculating the full picture carefully, he quickly chooses the higher-paying option because salary is the first thing he looks at. Which concept in psychological decision-making does this most closely illustrate?

A) Rational analysis of all available information B) Relying on an easily available piece of information as a shortcut rather than evaluating the whole situation C) A deliberate and justified prioritisation of financial security D) Emotional impulsivity overriding logical thinking

Q8. A student studying for an exam finds it much easier to recall information she read while listening to a specific song. When she hums that song quietly during revision the next day, more details come back to her. What psychological principle does this most directly reflect?

A) That music makes people more intelligent over time B) That memory retrieval can be improved when the conditions at recall match the conditions during learning C) That passive background noise always improves concentration and memory D) That emotional responses to music permanently change how the brain stores facts

Q9. A researcher presents two groups with the same medical procedure, described differently. Group A is told it has a 90% survival rate. Group B is told it has a 10% mortality rate. Group A is more willing to proceed, even though both descriptions convey identical information. What does this most usefully illustrate?

A) Group A has stronger medical knowledge than Group B B) The way information is presented can significantly influence how people respond to it, independent of the actual content C) People are generally more afraid of death than they are motivated by survival D) Medical decisions should always be made by doctors rather than patients

Q10. A student who learned to ride a bicycle as a child picks it up again easily after ten years without practice. A student who memorised a poem for a school play ten years ago cannot recall most of it today. What does the difference between these two situations most likely suggest?

A) Physical skills are remembered because they involve more effort to learn originally B) The poem student had a weaker memory than the cycling student C) Motor skills that are practised repeatedly tend to be retained differently from verbal information that is not regularly revisited D) Memories formed during childhood are always stronger than those formed in adulthood

Section 3: Emotions, Mental Health and Relationships

Q11. After doing poorly on a class test, one student thinks, "I am terrible at this subject and I will never improve." Another student thinks, "I did not prepare well enough this time and I know what to change." Both students received the same score. What psychological concept best explains the difference in how they are responding?

A) Differences in raw intelligence B) The way a person habitually explains and interprets events to themselves C) The difficulty level of the test relative to each student's background knowledge D) The quality of teaching they have each received

Q12. A student feels anxious before every public speaking task, even when she has prepared well and has been told she speaks clearly. She knows the anxiety is not based on evidence, but the feeling persists anyway. What does this most accurately reflect about emotions?

A) That she is not actually prepared well enough and needs to work harder B) That emotions do not always align neatly with rational assessment of a situation C) That public speaking anxiety indicates a serious psychological disorder requiring treatment D) That anxiety always disappears once a person has enough positive experience

Q13. A person finds it easy to stay calm and supportive when a close friend is going through a difficult time, even setting aside their own stress to do so. When an acquaintance faces a similar problem, they offer polite advice but feel much less personally invested. What does this pattern most directly illustrate?

A) That the person is behaving selfishly toward the acquaintance B) That empathy and emotional investment tend to be stronger in close relationships than in distant ones C) That the person lacks consistent values around helping others D) That emotional support is something people only offer when they expect something in return

Q14. A student has been feeling persistently tired, unmotivated, and disconnected from activities she used to enjoy. This has been going on for several weeks. Her grades have dropped slightly, though nothing dramatic has happened in her life recently. What is the most psychologically informed response to this situation?

A) This is normal teenage behaviour and will pass without any support B) These patterns are worth taking seriously as possible signs that her mental wellbeing needs attention, and talking to someone would be a reasonable step C) Because no specific event caused it, there is no real psychological issue present D) Declining grades are purely an academic problem unrelated to emotional wellbeing

Q15. A student notices that she feels much calmer after going for a run, even when the run itself is physically tiring. She starts running regularly on days when she feels overwhelmed. What does this most usefully reflect about the relationship between physical activity and psychological wellbeing?

A) That she is using exercise to avoid dealing with the real source of her stress B) That physical activity can serve as an effective way to regulate emotional states and manage stress C) That the benefits are temporary and do not address underlying psychological patterns D) That this only works for people who already enjoy exercise as a hobby

Section 4: Research Thinking and Psychological Analysis

Q16. A teacher observes that students who sit in the front rows of the classroom tend to get better grades than those who sit at the back. She concludes that sitting at the front causes students to perform better. What is the most significant problem with this conclusion?

A) The sample size is probably too small to draw any conclusion at all B) A pattern between two things does not by itself tell us that one is causing the other, since both could be influenced by a third factor C) Teachers are not qualified to conduct research on their own students D) Grade performance is too complex a variable to be studied in a classroom setting

Q17. A psychologist wants to understand how teenagers cope with academic pressure. She spends three months visiting schools, observing students in common areas, and having informal conversations with them. She does not give them questionnaires or tests. What kind of approach is she using, and what is its main advantage?

A) A laboratory experiment, which gives precise and controllable results B) A survey method, which allows her to gather data from large numbers of people efficiently C) A naturalistic and qualitative approach, which allows her to understand behaviour in real settings as it actually occurs D) A clinical method, which is used specifically to assess and treat psychological difficulties

Q18. A student reads an article claiming that people who eat breakfast perform better academically. She immediately concludes that eating breakfast makes students smarter. A classmate suggests the relationship might be more complicated. Which response reflects better psychological and scientific reasoning?

A) The first student, because the article provides direct evidence for the conclusion B) The second student, because recognising that a relationship between two variables could be more complex is a sign of more careful analytical thinking C) Neither student, because conclusions should only be drawn from very large studies D) The first student, because simple explanations are usually more accurate than complicated ones

Q19. Two researchers study why some students procrastinate on assignments. Researcher A interviews students in depth about their personal experiences. Researcher B gives a standardised questionnaire to 500 students and analyses the patterns statistically. A fellow researcher argues both approaches have genuine value. What is the strongest basis for this argument?

A) One method is always more scientific than the other and should be used exclusively B) Using two methods simultaneously cancels out the weaknesses of each C) Different methods reveal different things, and understanding behaviour fully often benefits from more than one type of evidence D) Researcher A's method is more valid because personal accounts are always more truthful than survey responses

Q20. A student watches a documentary about a criminal case and, based on the person's appearance and body language in interviews, concludes they must be guilty. She feels very confident in her judgement. What does this most clearly illustrate about psychological reasoning and human judgment?

A) That visual observation is one of the most reliable ways to assess whether someone is telling the truth B) That people can form confident conclusions based on limited and potentially misleading information, and that rigorous evidence matters more than intuition C) That the student has strong observational skills and would make a good researcher D) That documentary filmmakers are responsible for shaping misleading impressions in viewers

Answer Key and Explanations

Question	Correct Answer
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Q1	B
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Q2	C
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Q3	B
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Q4	B
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Q5	B
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Q6	C
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Q7	B
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Q8	B
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Q9	B
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Q10	C
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Q11	B
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Q12 B

Q13 B

Q14 B

Q15 B

Q16 B

Q17 C

Q18 B

Q19 C

Q20 B

Q1. Answer: B Individual differences in personality mean that two people can respond to the same situation in genuinely different ways. Neither response is incorrect; they simply reflect different temperaments and comfort zones.

Q2. Answer: C When behaviour is driven by personal interest and meaning rather than external rewards or pressure, psychologists describe this as intrinsic motivation. It tends to produce more sustained engagement than motivation that depends on outside incentives.

Q3. Answer: B The fact that two brothers raised in the same household developed distinct personalities illustrates that personality is shaped by a combination of individual biological factors and unique personal experiences, not environment alone.

Q4. Answer: B Emotional state has a well-documented effect on cognitive performance. Stress and emotional distress can reduce concentration and working memory, making it harder to access knowledge that is otherwise available.

Q5. Answer: B Conformity refers to adjusting visible behaviour to align with the group even when one's private views remain unchanged. This is distinct from genuine persuasion, where a person's underlying beliefs actually shift.

Q6. Answer: C Research on memory consistently shows that actively retrieving information, such as answering practice questions, strengthens retention more effectively than passive re-reading. The feeling of familiarity after reading can create a false sense of mastery.

Q7. Answer: B This describes the use of a cognitive heuristic, specifically anchoring on a single prominent piece of information rather than weighing all relevant factors. Such shortcuts are efficient but can lead to decisions that do not fully serve a person's interests.

Q8. Answer: B This illustrates context-dependent memory, the principle that recall is often stronger when the conditions at retrieval match those present during encoding. Environmental and sensory cues can act as effective retrieval aids.

Q9. Answer: B This is a classic illustration of the framing effect. Logically equivalent information presented in different ways produces different responses, demonstrating that human decision-making is shaped by presentation and not just content.

Q10. Answer: C Motor skills that are practised repeatedly tend to become deeply embedded and persist even without continued use. Verbal information such as a poem, if not revisited, typically fades more quickly because it relies on different memory systems.

Q11. Answer: B This reflects the concept of explanatory style, the habitual way a person interprets the causes of events in their life. Those who explain setbacks as permanent and global tend to feel more helpless, while those who see them as specific and changeable tend to respond more constructively.

Q12. Answer: B Emotions and rational assessment often operate independently. A person can know intellectually that a fear is unlikely to be justified while still experiencing the emotional response, which is why psychological approaches to anxiety involve more than information or reassurance alone.

Q13. Answer: B Empathy and emotional engagement are typically greater in close relationships where there is shared history and personal investment. This reflects a well-observed pattern in how emotional responsiveness is distributed across different types of relationships.

Q14. Answer: B Persistent low mood, fatigue, and loss of interest lasting several weeks are recognisable signs that a person's psychological wellbeing may need attention, even without an obvious trigger. Early recognition and conversation with a trusted person or professional are appropriate responses.

Q15. Answer: B Physical activity has a well-supported relationship with emotional regulation. It can reduce the physiological markers of stress and contribute to improved mood, making it a genuine and evidence-backed strategy for managing psychological pressure.

Q16. Answer: B This is the classic error of inferring causation from correlation. Students who choose to sit at the front may already be more motivated, making motivation the underlying factor rather than seat location. A pattern between two variables cannot by itself establish that one is causing the other.

Q17. Answer: C The approach described is qualitative and observational, gathering data from natural settings without structured instruments. Its key advantage is that it allows the researcher to understand behaviour as it actually occurs, in context, rather than as responses to artificial tasks.

Q18. Answer: B Recognising that a relationship between two variables could be influenced by additional factors, or that causation cannot be assumed from correlation, reflects more rigorous scientific thinking. Simple explanations are appealing but are not automatically more accurate.

Q19. Answer: C Qualitative interviews yield rich personal insight into individual experience, while quantitative surveys reveal patterns across large populations. The choice of method depends on what kind of understanding is being sought, and combining approaches often produces a fuller picture.

Q20. Answer: B People frequently form confident judgements based on limited information and unreliable cues, particularly when assessing character or deception from appearance. Psychological research consistently shows that such intuitive judgements are far less accurate than most people believe, which is why evidence matters more than confident impressions